

Romania is considering Ubuntu in schools

Plagued by a slew of unlicensed or old unsupported versions of proprietary software like Microsoft Windows and Microsoft Office in many of its schools, the Romanian Education Ministry is now considering a switch to open source solutions like GNU/Linux, Ubuntu and Edubuntu, in particular.

Recently, the Ministry released a tentative list of applications recommended to be used along with GNU/Linux: LibreOffice, Firefox, Inkscape, the GIMP, GNU Octave, FreeCAD, Geany and Lazarus, to name a few. However, as of now, the list is only 'experimental' with no specific information available regarding whether or not such a move will be made official at some point in time. "Until we can provide national support for this product, including localisation in Romanian and national minority languages, the decision to use this distribution is up to each school," a statement from the Ministry said.

Earlier, the Penn Manor High School in the US distributed as many as 1,725 'Linux' powered laptops to its students. Linux has now become the part and parcel of the 'entire' institution. For almost a decade, it powered the servers and provided the platform for the school's websites, storage, and learning management systems. So Linux was the natural choice when it came to providing its students the right learning tool. The Penn Manor High School has provided every student in grades 9-12 an Acer TravelMate laptop pre-loaded with Ubuntu 13.10.

Google Now launcher available in Google Play

Google has reportedly launched the Google Now launcher at the Google Play Store. The launcher, which was earlier called Google Experience, was only available to Nexus 5 users. The launcher can now be installed on all Android KitKat powered Nexus and Google Play edition devices.

The Google Now launcher comes with a dedicated home screen on the left, and users can trigger automatic voice-search/actions by calling out "Ok Google" when on the home screen. The "Ok Google" command is currently supported in US English, UK English and Canadian English.

The full feature list of the Google Now on the home screen, "Ok Google" 'hotword' support, faster search, a larger viewing area and an intuitive wallpaper picker. The Google Now launcher has aspects like the right information at just the right time, assistance around the clock, relevant suggestions, 'You're in control', and many more.

It supports weather reports, road and traffic routes, or even checking your favourite team's score while they're playing. It works in the background while the information is automatically organised into simple cards. Google claims that Google Now works the way you want, as it brings users customised and relevant information. The user can control the settings that determine the information Google Now provides.



A software that converts Android apps to Tizen OS!

Thanks to Korean software developer Infracore, developers will no longer have to sweat it out while manually porting their apps to Tizen OS. The software in question is the Polaris App Generator (PAG).

Using PAG software, developers will be able to readily convert Android APKs into Tizen OS executable files. With a simple click, the software "... adds a standalone Dalvik runtime to the compiled code, allowing it to run in Tizen OS without any special tweaks," said a statement from Infracore. However, the utility will come at a high price. Currently, the company is charging US\$ 5,000 per app, applicable for a period of two years. The hefty price, the company claims, will prevent pirates from misusing PAG.

Unfortunately, even as the service is raring to go, there is no sign of a 'true' Tizen smartphone yet. And by the looks of it, there is still a long way to go before we actually see one!

The Tizen Association is a Samsung and Intel-led industry group that has been guiding the Linux-based OS' development. It must be noted that Tizen is one of the only projects backed by a company as massive as Samsung, but having made so much money on Android, one wonders why Samsung is looking to leave it in the first place? If a leaked screenshot of a phone, currently doing the rounds on the social media, is anything to go by, then Samsung ZEQ 9000 could very well be the much awaited phone from the South Korean giant featuring the 'Tizen' OS. The screenshot was leaked by a Korean publication called 'Moveplayer'.

